4. Team-Based Creativity and Innovation

by

1. Adamu Esubalew (PhD)
2. Mohammed Zeinu (MA)

Addis Ababa Science and Technology University

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Objectives

The main objective of this part will be analyzing the importance of team-based creativity and innovation, and implementing team-based creativity and innovation.

At the end of this unit, you will be able to:

- identify the nature of creativity and innovation
- analyze the importance of team-based creativity and innovation, and
- implement team-based creativity and innovation.

Training outlines

- Nature of team-based creativity and innovation
- Importance of team-based creativity and innovation
- Mechanisms to establish effective teams for creativity, and innovation strategies to enhance team-based creativity and innovation.

4.1. Nature of Team-Based Creativity and Innovation

Team-based creativity and innovation involve collaborative processes where a group of individuals generate novel and useful ideas, leading to the development of new products, services, or processes.

Different team members may possess unique skills and expertise that contribute to a more comprehensive understanding of problems and the development of creative solutions.

Team members can build on each other's ideas, refining and expanding them into more robust concepts.

Effective team-based creativity and innovation relies on an environment where members feel comfortable sharing their ideas without fear of criticism.

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- Open communication encourages risk-taking and experimentation.
- Team members must practice **active listening** to understand and appreciate each other’s contributions fully.
- This respect for diverse opinions enhances collaboration.
- Creativity and innovation in teams is often an iterative process involving brainstorming, feedback, refinement, prototyping, and commercialization.
- This dynamic approach allows for continuous improvement of ideas.

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The **nature of team-based** creativity and innovation is characterized by the following key aspects:

Diversity of thought: varied perspectives and complementary skills,

Collaboration and interaction: collective brainstorming and building on ideas,

Shared goals and vision: common objectives and collective ownership,

Open communication: safe environment for expression and active listening,

Dynamic process: iterative nature and flexibility,

Continuous learning: continuous refinement and revision of the activities

Integration of technology: digital collaboration tool and data-driven insights, and

Outcome orientation: innovation as a goal and evaluation and feedback.

4.2. Importance of Team-Based Creativity and Innovation

- Team-based creativity and innovation offers numerous benefits that can enhance problem-solving and overall productivity within organizations.
- Teams bring together individuals with different backgrounds, experiences, and viewpoints, leading to a broader range of ideas and solutions.
- Working in teams can boost morale and motivation, as team members' support and inspire each other, which can lead to higher levels of engagement and commitment to release their projects.

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- Team-based creativity and innovation encourages open communication and dialogue, fostering an environment where all ideas are valued, which can lead to more effective collaboration and fewer misunderstandings.
- Teams create a sense of accountability, as members rely on each other to contribute, which encourage individuals to take risks and share bold ideas they might hesitate to present alone.
- Teams can be more alert in responding to changes or challenges, which leads to better collaboration on future projects.

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Some key importance of team-based creativity and innovation are the followings:

- ✓ Consider diverse perspectives,
- ✓ Increase motivation and engagement,
- ✓ Enhance problem-solving capabilities,
- ✓ Increase rate of creativity and innovation cycles,
- ✓ Better decision-making,
- ✓ Knowledge sharing and learning,
- ✓ Strengthen relationships and team cohesion,
- ✓ Enhance adaptability to change,
- ✓ Increase quality outcomes, and
- ✓ Enhance competitive advantage.

Activity 4.1: Group discussion

Dear trainees, please discuss in groups on the following discussion points, and present your reflections.

1. Explain the nature of team-based creativity and innovation.
2. Identify the importance of team-based creativity and innovation.
3. Describe how to foster team-based creativity and innovation.
4. Explain the challenges of team-based creativity and innovation over individual -based creativity and innovation.
5. Demonstrate the mechanisms to reduce the challenges of team-based creativity and innovation.

4.3. Mechanisms to establish effective teams for creativity and innovation

To establish effective teams for creativity and innovation, it is required to examine the relationships between aspects of:

- **the team task** (intrinsically and extrinsically motivating task characteristics),
- **team composition** (personality of team members, skill and diversity),
- **organizational context** (rewards, learning and development practices, and climate),
- **team processes** (including norms for innovation, leadership, reflexivity, inter-group relations, conflict and dissent) and
- effectiveness of team creativity and innovation.

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The **mechanisms to establish effective teams** for creativity and innovation are described in the following paragraphs:

- **Ensure the team task is intrinsically motivating**: It is required to ensure that teams have tasks.
- **Ensure a high level of extrinsic demands**: Create conditions within which teams are exposed to high but not excessive levels of external demands.
- **Select a team of innovative people**: Include team members who have the personality trait of openness, who think in novel and non-conventional ways.
- **Select people with diverse skills and backgrounds**: Select team members who have task relevant skills, a diverse a range of skills and professional backgrounds
- **Provide organizational rewards for innovation:** It makes sense to argue that what should be rewarded is not the success of innovation but genuine attempts at innovation.

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- **Create a learning and development climate in the organization:** Encourage team innovation by developing supportive human resource management practices.
- **Develop a climate for innovation in the organization:** Establish operational systems that focus on managing team works
- **Establish team norms for innovation:** Encourage teams to be innovative and verbally and practically support team members.
- **Encourage reflexivity in teams:** Teams benefit from taking time out from working to reflect on their work habits, objectives, team processes and outcomes.

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- **Ensure there is clarity of leadership in the team:** The leadership in the team is clear to all team members and that there is no conflict over leadership.
- **Manage conflict constructively and encourage minorities to dissent within teams:** Encourage moderate task-related conflict and minority dissent, which leads to alternative interpretations of information available.
- **Don't just bond … bridge:** Encourage different teams to work together, share best practice, and develop joint projects to encourage the innovation that springs from bridging boundaries.

4.4. Strategies to enhance and promote team-based creativity and innovation

Enhancing team-based creativity and innovation requires **intentional strategies.**

There are various strategies to foster and promote team-based creativity and innovation.

ⓘ Some of the strategies are the followings:

- Promote an environment where all ideas are valued, and team members feel comfortable for expressing themselves without fear of judgment.
- Implement brainstorming sessions, mind mapping, and role-playing exercises to stimulate creative thinking.

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- Set clear objectives for creative and innovative projects to align team efforts and ensure everyone understands the desired outcomes.
- Recognize **both successful** innovations and valuable **lessons** learned from failures to encourage continuous experimentation.
- Ensure teams have access to the necessary tools, technology, and training to support their creative processes.
- Engage in activities that strengthen relationships among team members, enhancing collaboration and trust.

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- For creativity and innovation implementation to emerge from team functioning for teams to be sparkling fountains of ideas and changes.
- Team members have the integration abilities to work effectively.
- They develop a safe psychosocial climate and appropriate group processes (clarifying objectives, encouraging participation, constructive controversy, reflexivity and support for innovation).

Activity 4.2: Group discussion

Dear trainees, please discuss in groups on the following discussion points, and present your reflections.

1. Identify the mechanisms to establish effective teams for creativity and innovation.
2. Explain how you work collaboratively with other employees; accept their creative and innovative ideas and suggestions.
3. Describe the strategies how team-based creativity and innovation are enhanced and promoted.
4. Demonstrate the effects of strategies on the performance of team-based creativity and innovation projects and programs.

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For creativity and innovation implementation to emerge from team functioning for teams to be sparkling fountains of ideas and changes, and the context must be demanding but there must be strong group integration processes and a high level of intra-group safety.

This requires that members have the integration abilities to work effectively in teams; and that they develop a safe psychosocial climate and appropriate group processes (clarifying objectives, encouraging participation, constructive controversy, reflexivity and support for innovation).

Thank You!